

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: accounting-firm • SaaS Startup • 28 Employees • \$3.5M Revenue • R&D; Credit Missed

2026-05-14 01:10 PM

DecisionBrief: Thinking about an accounting firm? Tell me about your business and what you need from the relationship?

You: I run a SaaS startup in Austin — Delaware C-Corp, 28 W2 employees, \$3.5M ARR, plus one subsidiary for contractors in India. We use QuickBooks Online but books are messy — 6 months behind on close. Currently with local CPA — \$800/month for bookkeeping + \$5k for tax. He missed R&D; credit last year, took 3 weeks to reply, and year-end took 4 months. We are raising Seed in Q3 and need clean books.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — Delaware C-Corp + India subsidiary, 28 W2, \$3.5M ARR, QBO messy 6 months behind, local CPA \$800/mo + \$5k tax, missed R&D; credit, 3-week reply, 4-month year-end, raising Seed Q3. What triggered the need to switch now?

You: Two triggers — we got an IRS notice for 2023 payroll mismatch \$12k and CPA took 2 weeks to respond. And investor asked for monthly financials with burn and runway and we couldn't produce — close is 6 months behind. Also we expanded to sales tax in 7 states and CPA said he doesn't handle multi-state. Tax deadline Sept 15 for extension.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — IRS notice \$12k payroll mismatch slow response, investor needs monthly close with burn/runway. 6 months behind. 7-state sales tax new. extension Sept 15. What have you considered so far?

You: Looked at Pilot, Bench, and a boutique SaaS firm Kruze-like. Pilot quoted \$2,200/month for bookkeeping + tax not included, Bench \$600/month but no R&D; or multi-state. Local boutique quoted \$1,500/month including tax and R&D; credit. Friend said stay with current and hire controller but I don't want \$90k salary. Also considered hiring in-house bookkeeper \$55k but still need CPA.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — Pilot \$2,200/mo, Bench \$600/mo no R&D;, boutique \$1,500/mo incl tax + R&D;, in-house bookkeeper \$55k and controller \$90k considered. What's your budget and constraints?

You: Currently \$800/month + \$5k tax = about \$14,600/year. Can go to \$18k hard cap \$30k if perfect annually including bookkeeping and tax and R&D;. Monthly payment needed, can't do big upfront. Need someone live by July 1 to fix QBO before Seed. Must be able to handle Delaware C-Corp, subsidiary, multi-state 7 states, and communicate on Slack with 24-48 hour reply, not 3 weeks. Need monthly close by 15th.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — \$14.6k now, \$18k cap \$30k perfect, monthly payments, live by July 1 before Seed and Sept 15 extension. What must the firm actually do?

You: Must do monthly bookkeeping and close by 15th with accrual, burn, runway, deferred revenue for SaaS, cleanup QBO 6 months behind, handle Delaware C-Corp tax plus R&D; credit we missed last year — we spent \$180k on engineering, handle payroll tax and 1099s for 15 contractors, sales tax in 7 states, and be able to give advisory for fundraising — cap table, 409A. And be responsive on Slack, not email only. Integration with QBO, Gusto, Stripe, Brex.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — monthly close by 15th accrual burn runway deferred revenue, QBO cleanup 6 months behind, Delaware C-Corp tax + R&D; credit \$180k engineering, payroll 1099s 15 contractors, 7-state sales tax, fundraising advisory cap table 409A, Slack 24-48hr, QBO/Gusto/Stripe/Brex integrations. What worries you most about switching?

You: Switching mid-year losing history or QBO getting messed more, firm low-balls \$1,500/month then bills \$8k extra at year end for R&D; and multi-state, misses IRS \$12k notice deadline and we get penalties, doesn't understand SaaS deferred revenue and messes up books for Seed, and we pay \$30k and still get 3-week replies. Also boutique firm might be too small if we grow to 50 employees next year.

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DecisionBrief: Thanks — mid-year switch losing history, \$8k extra billing surprise for R&D; + multi-state, IRS \$12k notice penalty risk, SaaS deferred revenue mishandled for Seed, \$30k with slow reply, boutique too small for 50 employees scale are kev. What does success look like in 12 months?

You: In 12 months books closed by 15th every month with burn and runway accurate, QBO cleaned from 6 months behind, R&D; credit filed for \$180k engineering and saved taxes, IRS \$12k notice resolved with no penalty, 7-state sales tax compliant, 1099s and payroll tax clean, Seed raised with clean financials investor liked, total under \$18k/year, Slack replies within 24-48 hours not 3 weeks, and CPA proactively tells us about tax moves before Sept 15 deadline, not after.

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DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.